

New CM Eknath Shinde with his grandson after the oath-taking ceremony, Mumbai, June 30

MANDAR DEODHAR

EKNATH SHINDE

MAN OF FEW WORDS

Built of the same suburban grit in which he was groomed, the gruff and taciturn Shinde is emblematic of the streetside Shiv Sainik

The regal grandeur of a Bal Thackeray, the timid artist-like graces of his son Uddhav, the peshwa-in-waiting vibes of his cousin Raj, the smooth Brahmin wiles of a Devendra Fadnavis...he has none of this. Indeed, for a party like the Shiv Sena, built around charismatic speechifiers, he doesn't even speak much. Who exactly is Eknath Shinde then? Gruff, bearded, clad in slovenly white, built of the same suburban grit that groomed him, one clue can be found in the fact that he led a spectacular coup against his own party—deposing a Thackeray, no less—yet did so by refusing to *leave* his party. Yes, the air of a proletarian come to grips with a raw form of empowerment is unmistakable: Shinde is nothing if not emblematic of the lakhs of Shiv Sainiks who are the lifeblood of the party. Someone who, for all his streetside swag, broke into tears of humility when felicitated on his 58th birthday on February 9 on hometurf Thane.

Old associates say the best word to describe him is: stubborn. India saw that in action last week. Before that, the Thanekars knew it—he was like that through the ups and downs of personal and political life. Two years after he first got elected to the Thane Municipal Corporation in 1997, Shinde lost two of his three sons in a drowning accident in native Satara. He almost quit politics to return to farming. It was his mentor-guru, Sena strongman Anand Dighe, who dissuaded him. Dighe had picked him up in the early 1980s when he was working as a supervisor at a chemical firm, driving an autorickshaw to supplement his income.

Shinde has a pre-Sena political past too. As a Thane schoolboy, he was attracted to the RSS—old-timers recall him attending the shakha for children at Kisan Nagar. But as an assertive teenager, Shinde took a shine to the muscular ways of the Sena. Under Dighe, he became *shakha pramukh* in 1984, then corporator. Thence, he rose as MLA (from Kopri-Pachpakhadi, since 2004), minister and now, finally, CM. The beard he sports, and often plays with as he listens to people wordlessly for hours, is homage by imitation to the charismatic Dighe. Those listening skills will stand him in good stead now. ■